11

Rose

In the darkness, it took all Rose's effort to hold back the panic churning inside her. She clung tightly to the metal rungs, terrified that if she moved her hands or feet, the walls of the tunnel would press in and crush her. Her palms grew sweaty, and her breathing became ragged and uneven. The darkness left her disoriented. But she had to force her way through it. Move. Taking a deep breath, she eased her grip on one rung, then another.

Something landed on her head. She shook her hair, fearing it was a spider, but it seemed to be a clump of dirt from the ceiling. And that's when she felt the vibration overhead.

Could it be Léa? Reaching for the metal rung, she climbed back up toward the hatch. She intended to unlock it so Léa could enter. But halfway up, more dirt rained down like fine dust, forcing her to stop. If it was Léa, wouldn't she knock on the hatch to alert Rose? Listening intently for voices, she heard none. A sudden realization hit her—Léa wouldn't be wandering back and forth; she knew the location of the hatch and would either knock on it or find another way back to the vineyard. Someone had taken Léa, and now they were searching for Rose.

Think of Virginie and Paulette. Her sister's last words echoed in her mind. If something happened to Rose, Virginie and Paulette would be left alone. With a steely resolve, Rose shimmied down to the rail carts, punching through the fear and keeping one hand on the tunnel wall to guide her all the way back to the opening.

As her fingers scraped the limestone, Rose kept thinking about Léa. Would they bring her to the town hall and put her in the same room with Édouard? It wouldn't take the authorities long to figure out Léa's